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1 Introduction

This case study aims to analyse the language development of Mali. Mali is a four-year-old Aboriginal child. The analysis incorporates the lens of parents and home environment, as well as peers and educators. Language development is an important domain in early childhood education. It determines children's ability to communicate, form relationships, and engage in learning. Communication also involves expressions and receptive language along with pragmatic skills that is very important for social interaction (McCormack et al., 2024).

This analysis examines interactions with social elements like adults and peers shape Mali's language development as it draws from sociocultural perspectives, particularly Lev Vygotsky concept of the Zone of Proximal Development (Chaiklin, 2003). This discussion aims to identify Mali's strengths and challenges in expressive, receptive, and pragmatic language within her home and educational contexts. Furthermore, two evidence-based strategies which are aligned with the Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF V2) are also proposed in this study. This will support her ongoing language development.

2 Analysis: Language Development through Parents and Peers/Educators

Mali's interactions within her home environment strongly shape her language development. This can be seen particularly with her relationship with her mother, Leah. Mali listens, reflects and revisits questions over time without asking questions impulsively. This communication pattern shows that her receptive language is well-developed. This also aligns with the understanding that communication involves both expressive and receptive language as comprehension often develops alongside or prior to verbal expression (McCormack et al., 2024). The calm and responsive communication style of Leah ensures a language-rich environment. Hence, Mali is exposed to consistent modelling and feedback which are important for language acquisition. This aligns with the understanding that children develop foundational communication skills through such interactions, where the caregivers actively engage, respond, and scaffold understanding (McCormack et al., 2024).

3

From a sociocultural perspective, the Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD) theory developed by Lev Vygotsky states that people learn through their direct interactions with superior

knowledge holders. Mali learns to speak English because Leah takes time to explain things until she understands and can express her thoughts to others (Chaiklin, 2003). The essential development of Mali's skills shows her ability to think about herself while she builds understanding through extended practice. However, her tendency to respond slowly and revisit ideas suggests that her expressive language, particularly spontaneous verbalisation, is still developing.

In a similar way, Mali's interaction with her father, Daniel also shows the role of home environment in supporting language development. Daniel makes sure that Mali is engaged in everyday routines and conversations. This helps in providing meaningful contexts to communication. At first, Mali's response is of minimal verbal output but as she becomes more comfortable, he elaborates on her experiences. This behaviour displays the developmental nature of expressive language. In language development of children, time and supportive contexts are very important in order to organise and articulate children's thoughts (McCormack et al., 2024). Since, Mali gradually expands her responses, it shows that Mali is developing her expressive language skills, mainly in structuring narratives and recalling experiences. These interactions align with ZPD, as her father, Daniel's prompts and questions act as scaffolds which help support Mali's emerging language abilities (Chaiklin, 2003). Thus, a key strength is her ability to extend language when emotionally secure, while a challenge remains in initiating extended communication independently.

Mali's language development is not only limited to her home environment. It is significantly influenced by her interactions with her peers and educators. This is very evident in her kindergarten environment. Her relationship with her peer Zara shows a notable increase in expressive and pragmatic language. At the time of play, Mali is seen using more extended and long sentences. She also contributes ideas and engages in collaborative storytelling. Preschool-aged children typically use language in social contexts to suggest ideas, negotiate roles, and maintain relationships (McCormack et al., 2024). Mali actively participates in dramatic plays where she uses language to organise play scenarios and communicate intentions. Mali also experiments with language in a meaningful and engaging way within the play-based context. This supports her expressive and pragmatic development.

The Vygotsky theory states that people acquire their advanced mental abilities through social interactions which they later learn to control. The process manifests through Mali's enhanced

ability to speak with Zara because she can learn language skills by playing with her supportive friend. The ZPD framework supports peer learning because experienced students lead their younger classmates through joint study tasks (Chaiklin, 2003). Through expanding play narratives Zara helps Mali develop her language skills because she presents her new ideas and words. The capacity of Mali to use advanced language which suits different social situations represents one of her development strengths.

Despite all these progresses, Mali also faces challenges in her pragmatic language. This is especially evident with her interactions with less familiar peers. When some other children interrupt her play or change the established scenarios, she struggles to negotiate verbally. She may resort to crying, withdrawing or even seeking adult support. Pragmatic language also involves the ability to use language properly in social contexts. It means using language to negotiate, turn-take and resolve conflicts as well (McCormack et al., 2024). Since Mali faces difficulties in handling these situations, it shows that her pragmatic skills are still developing. When play changes unexpectedly, she is frustrated which shows that there is limited flexibility in adapting language to social interactions which are dynamic and changing.

The case study also shows that she is developing in these areas. Mali is beginning to use language in more specific way. She expresses her needs such as asking her peers to wait or explain her intentions. Teachers demonstrate their ability to support language development through their practice of giving students guidance and showing them effective communication methods. Students learn to use pragmatic language skills through structured environments that educators create which include peer interaction and questioning and their ability to express their ideas (McCormack et al., 2024). Guided coaching helps Mali learn to use language for social negotiation instead of depending on his emotional responses.

The process of language development in Mali needs play because it acts as a vital component. During their dramatic play activities, children use language to make pretend worlds and choose character roles while they share their understanding of the play. Through play Children develop the ability to use language for symbolic purposes while they learn to differentiate between different meanings which they derive from real objects (Kravtsov & Kravtsova, 2010). Through her pretend play with Zara Mali demonstrates her skills to use language in both creative and practical ways. This fundamental strength enables her to demonstrate advanced language skills

together with cognitive flexibility. She struggles with sudden changes during playtime because she finds it hard to manage the ever-changing nature of social interactions.

Mali's language development shows a strong foundation in receptive language. This is shaped by her interactions within her home and educational environments. Her relationships with parents and familiar peers allow her to communicate freely and effectively. She faces challenges in less predictable social contexts. Sociocultural theory makes it clear that Mali's interactions have a significant impact on her development, and that guided support is essential to improving her language skills.

3 Understanding Language Development and Its Importance

Language development is a key domain in early childhood educations. It involves the following:

- Expressive language which means producing messages
- Receptive language which means understanding messages
- Pragmatic language which means using language appropriately in social contexts

These different components are interconnected as they rely on form (syntax and phonology), content (semantics), and use (pragmatics). Together, these factors allow children to communicate effectively across various different situations (McCormack et al., 2024). In preschools, children expand their vocabulary, make more complex sentences and increasingly use language to express their ideas and participate in social interactions.

Interaction with others develops language rather than isolation. Lev Vygotsky states that learning is socially mediated. Higher mental functions emerge through interaction before they are internalised (Chaiklin, 2003). This highlights the critical role of parents, educators, and peers in shaping children's communication abilities.

Teachers need to understand language development because it serves as the basis for children to acquire new knowledge and establish relationships with others and express their needs. Teachers create supportive environments that promote language development by using their knowledge of language growth to implement effective methods which help students develop their communication skills.

4 Strategies to Support Mali's Language Development

The following strategies are aligned with the Early Years Learning Framework (EYLF V2) and grounded in sociocultural theory.

4.1 Strategy 1: Scaffolded conversational interactions in play-based contexts

Educators can intentionally involve Mali in responsive conversations during play. A familiar context such as home corner or storytelling activity must be maintained. Educators must use open-ended questions, model extended sentences and allow him to process before expecting responses. Such interactions align with Lev Vygotsky concept of the Zone of Proximal Development. Learning occurs through a guided support from more knowledgeable others (Chaiklin, 2003). By scaffolding Mali's communication, educators can gradually support her transition from short responses to more elaborated language.

The knowledge that children learn language through modelling, feedback, and engagement in relevant circumstances lends credence to this approach (McCormack et al., Year). Additionally, it is consistent with EYLF Outcome 5: Children are proficient communicators, especially when it comes to growing vocabulary and gaining confidence in spoken communication. By incorporating language support into play, Mali can improve her expressive language in a comfortable, low-stress setting, enhancing her comfort level with organized, purposeful activities.

4.2 Strategy 2: Facilitating peer interaction and guided conflict resolution

In order to address Mali's challenges in pragmatic language, educators can implement collaborative play with peers. It is important to involve familiar children such as Zara and provide guidance during moments of conflict. This includes modelling language for negotiation (e.g., "Can I have a turn after you?"), prompting Mali to express her ideas verbally, and supporting her in adapting to changes in play scenarios.

Children learn to negotiate, take turns, and create relationships through social engagement, which is how pragmatic language develops (McCormack et al., Year). Sociocultural theory states that prior to internalization, higher brain functions develop through social contact (Kravtsov & Kravtsova, 2010). Teachers can help Mali acquire the language necessary to handle social situations more skilfully by assisting her during peer interactions.

1 This approach helps Mali express her thoughts, negotiate with others, and form relationships, which is in line with EYLF Outcomes 1 (Children have a strong sense of identity) and 5 (Children are skilled communicators). Mali can improve her social skills and language development by progressively substituting verbal communication for emotional reactions via supervised practice.